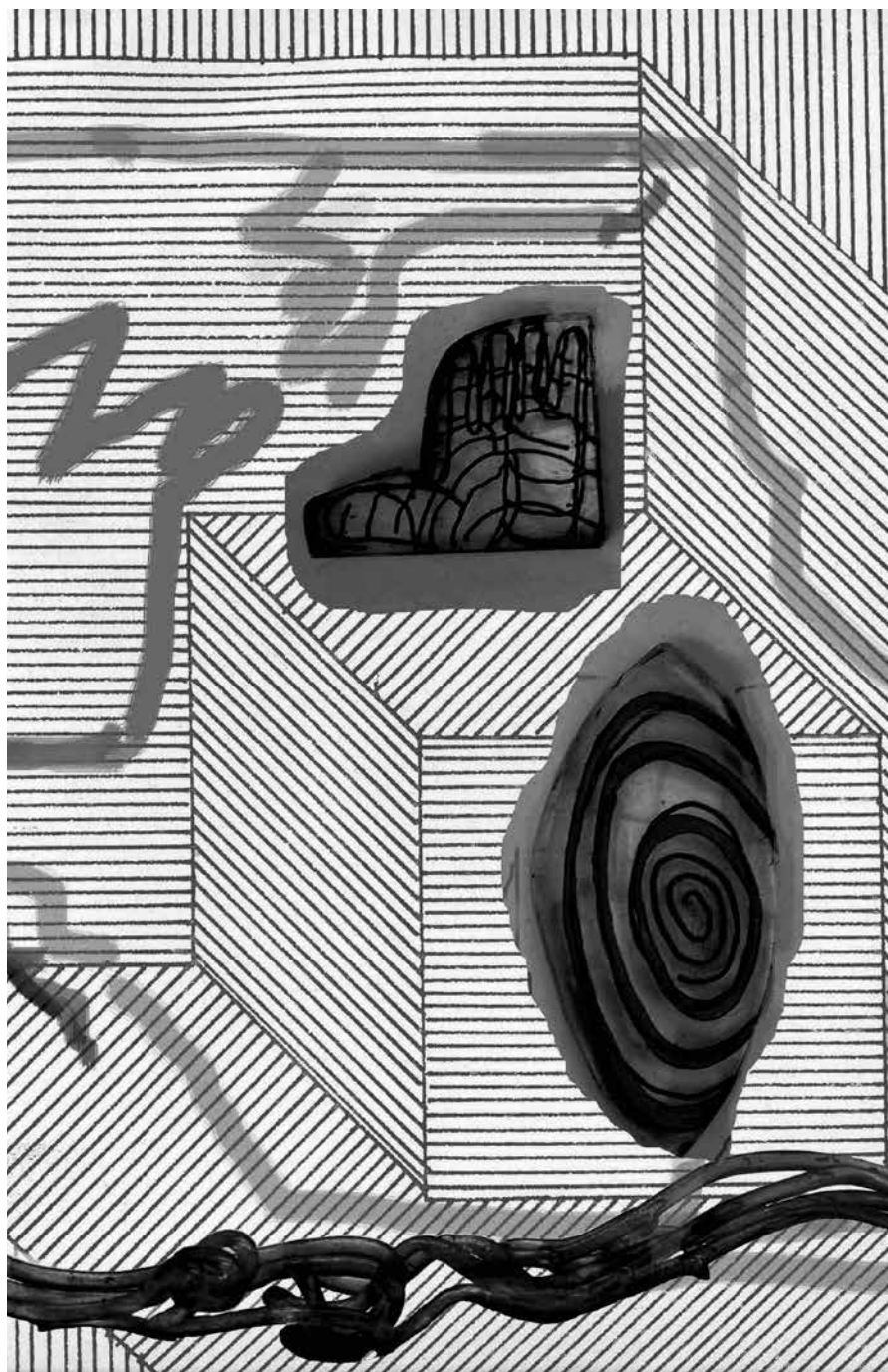




Agathe Sorel Hand and Eye coordination, 1959

Chapter 2: Paris - Dreams Fulfilled

I received my scholarship money through the Paris offices of the Gulbenkian Foundation and my temporary travel documents from the Home Office in the autumn of 1958. On arrival, I stayed with a family for a few weeks, where I received a room in return for giving the daughter some English conversation lessons. I also tried out French lessons at the Alliance Française but I only found English people there so left quite soon afterwards as it was not really improving my French. I wandered around the marvellous city in a dream; the beauty of the architecture, the galleries, the museums, and the liveliness of the intellectual climate was intoxicating. I then enrolled at l'École des Beaux-Arts, which was also rather disappointing; the teaching seemed very old fashioned and the classrooms unsafe as expensive paints and materials were stolen from lockers or just disappeared from the easels.

However, the Atelier 17, recommended by Michael Rothenstein and Julian Trevelyan, was just what I needed. As for my French, my solution was somewhat cheeky. I subscribed to a modern French literature course at the Sorbonne, in spite of my poor French.

Nobody asked any questions, I paid the very reasonable fees and had graduate qualifications, so I was allowed to attend lectures. There were about 300-400 other students in one of the great halls of the school, crammed in to the point of being unable to sit down or take notes.

The authors first discussed were André Gide and Jean-Paul Sartre. These were the most inspiring lectures I have ever attended! I was also entitled to use the library opposite the Luxembourg gardens.

The librarian allowed me to borrow books and seeing my poor language skills, came up with a strange suggestion; I should not start by reading modern literature, but try an author, who used very simple style and construction. So, I began reading the works of George Sand, whom the librarian greatly admired; a fascinating character, lover and muse to Chopin, an early feminist, who also wrote great novels. At first, I had to look up almost every word in the dictionary; then, I understood more and more and with a bit of practical experience was finally able to follow my course. The Sorbonne also had the finest student restaurant, where we could

eat well for very little cost.

Education in those days was regarded as a social stabilizer, a solution to class division and strife, the bedrock of democracy. Therefore, it was the duty of the state to spread it as wide as possible to benefit everyone who wished and there were a number of grants for the exceptionally gifted.

I am very conscious of being the beneficiary of such a system which allowed me to study without accumulating the huge debts that students tend to be burdened with these days.

S.W. Hayter and the Atelier 17

Stanley William Hayter, whom we all called Bill, was a truly magnetic personality, a fierce angel on a mission, with piercing blue eyes and blondish hair, which he tossed back like a thoroughbred racehorse.

He believed, perhaps a little naively, in the social power of the arts. He also encouraged experimentation and pushing the boundaries of creativity to its limits. He created a worldwide network of artist friends and assumed that history could be changed by developing a different mind-set.

Hayter came from an artistic family. His father was a painter, but Hayter had a scientific and logical mind and studied chemistry and geology at King's College London.

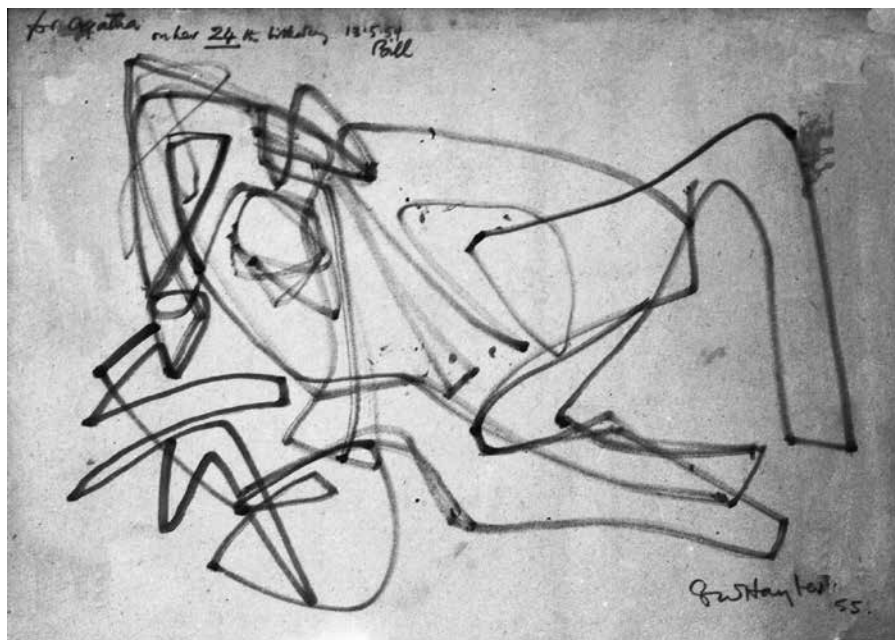
An interesting research job followed with the Anglo-Persian Oil Company in Iran. However, in a couple of years he got restless, having realized that he would not rise to the top in this field. He contracted malaria and was sent home and at this point his employers organised an exhibition for him of the paintings and drawings he had made whilst in Iran. The exhibition was a huge success and almost all the works sold. This probably convinced him to make art his future.



Bill Hayter set up the Atelier 17 where he encouraged artists with their prints.



Bill Hayter and the American artist, Helen Phillips



Hayter made this drawing with a felt tip pen and then dedicated it to me for my birthday

In 1926, he decided to go to Paris in one of the most exciting periods of its artistic history. Dada and Surrealism had completely transformed the art scene to something unpredictable and exciting, relying on coincidence and the subconscious.

In 1933, Hayter moved his studio to 17 Rue Campagne-Première where it became known as Atelier or Studio 17.

Atelier 17 was a glazed conservatory structure attached to an apartment block with a small front yard. It was bitterly cold in winter and boiling hot in the summer. The facilities were basic to say the least; there was no hot water and no heating. It was, however, in a good position, near the Luxembourg Gardens, with plenty of cafés and shops nearby, where most of the artists; writers, poets and philosophers congregated. It soon became very popular, a fixed point in the ever-changing bohemian scene, where artists could experiment and learn techniques they had never heard of before. They also had help with proofing and editioning their prints and books, mostly by student artists, who came to work with Bill from all over the world.

The pre-war regulars included Pablo Picasso, Juan Miró, Marc



Picasso at his Vallauris ceramics studio

Chagall, Jacques Lipchitz, Yves Tanguy, André Masson, and Salvador Dalí. Louise Bourgeois, Louise Nevelson, Jean Hélion, Max Ernst, and Alberto Giacometti. Hayter also collaborated with Wassily Kandinsky on a book. These artists always invited not only Hayter, but everyone working in the Atelier to attend their exhibitions and private views. They were well known artists at the time, but by no means as famous and rich as they were to become. They were friendly and approachable, ready to discuss their ideas with the students.

I remember an exhibition of Picasso ceramics in 1959, where the magnificent series made in Vallauris were on show. This body of work was dismissed by critics, who could not accept that ceramics could be fine art. The exhibition was very poorly attended and hardly anyone showed up at the private view. Picasso was pleased to talk to the students, who eventually filled the gallery.

<https://youtu.be/bywSiAglgM> Picasso in Vallauris

<https://youtu.be/KPbjMglaxE> Madoura Collection of Picasso Ceramics

S. W. Hayter,
Tarantelle, colour
etching, 1943



I also remember Miró visiting the studio. He was very shy and did not talk much, but on one visit, he saw an engraved plate with great automatic loops, looking like a football flying through the air. He drew a foot next to it straight onto the plate to look as if it was kicking the ball away. We kept this plate and a print of it for a very long time.

In 1980, Hayter gave a talk at the Bankside Gallery to mark his 80th birthday. He explained how the Atelier 17 became the only fixed point for artists at the time, as many artists led a bohemian life style and moved about, mostly under cover of the night as they

could not or would not pay their rent. At the Atelier, they could work, and get technical tuition by experts. They could edition and sell their work to galleries or to print publishers.

In 1940, Hayter moved to New York together with the “Pope of Surrealism” André Breton and many other leading European modernists. There, the Atelier 17 was recreated and many eminent American artists made prints there, including Jackson Pollock, Robert Motherwell, Alexander Calder, and Mark Rothko, to name but a few. Bill’s input and interaction inspired the artists involved in the new movement of abstract expressionism. The exchange of ideas and techniques affected all concerned and changed the art world on both sides of the Atlantic for good.

In 1950, Hayter returned to France where he found artwork had been stolen and most of the equipment ruined. He reopened Atelier 17, accommodating over 30 students who paid very reasonable fees. Some came for just a few weeks, some for a year or more, as their circumstances allowed. This created some difficulties in the teaching, which was individually tailored to the student’s needs. Hayter came in two to three times a week, whilst the messieurs as they were known, Dadi Wirtz and Krishna Reddy¹⁵ helped out the rest of the time. Sunday was Bill’s time to work and edition his own prints.

My boyfriend (later husband) Gábor Sitkey used to visit me every three or four months and he helped out a few times and received some signed proofs as payment.

Hayter made a drawing with a felt tip pen and then dedicated to me for my birthday.

In 1951, Bill received the Légion d’Honneur, the greatest honour that the French government can bestow. He wore the ribbons with great pride on the lapel of his only tweed suit. Not to be left behind, the Queen awarded him an OBE in the same year, which was rather controversial at the time as his work was neither appreciated nor understood in his native England.



S. W. Hayter with
Désirée Moorhead,
May 1973

¹⁵See Part 8, Chapter 14 for further details about Krishna Reddy

Bill lived a short distance from the Atelier in Rue Boissonade, in a huge underground studio, built under the courtyard of an apartment building. Magnificent light came through the flat roof, which was constructed from glass bricks, but it was always bitterly cold, with very basic amenities. The shower was made up of slats of wood and not much else. His second wife Helen, a talented sculptor and printmaker, often took to bed to file and polish her roughly cast bronze sculptures, because she was so cold.

Hayter's two sons with Helen, who were a bit younger than me, were in a boarding school in England.

Helen eventually eloped with her bronze-caster lover, to live in the Hayter's ramshackle house in Albi, which almost permanently had a hole in the roof. Guests were invited to sit around in a circle, watching the rainwater drop down. I too often hosted dinner parties in my apartment.

When things did not work out between Helen and her technician, she went back to New York, where she owned a brownstone house.

Bill, in his mid- 60s when Helen left, was still a bit of a lady's man; he was initially devastated, but found consolation with a talented and wealthy Irish student, Desirée Moorhead who was in her mid-20s at the time. She looked after him for the rest of his life, and, when he died in 1988, created a catalogue raisonné of his work together with art historian and curator Peter Black.

I was lucky enough, thanks to the Gulbenkian grant, to be able to rent a large and very civilized apartment opposite the Hayter's home and studio, which was well heated and had a proper bathroom and kitchen. We saw quite a lot of each other during this period and organized a couple of memorable parties.

Józef Hecht

When Bill Hayter arrived in Paris, he apprenticed himself to Józef Hecht, the famous Polish-Jewish engraver and learnt the demanding art of burin engraving, one of the earliest of printing techniques. However, they used this ancient method in a most unconventional way. Hecht himself was so impressed by Bill's progress and originality, that he helped him to buy a large etching press and establish Atelier 17.

Józef Hecht was born in 1891 and trained at the Academy of Fine Arts in Poland, specializing in line engraving. He travelled widely in Europe to visit museums, but settled in Paris in 1919, where he exhibited widely and started teaching line engraving in his studio. His work could be characterized to be an intermediary between avant-garde art and traditional engraving. His work was greatly appreciated and won several prizes including two gold medals at the International World Fair in 1926. It is worth noting that when Hayter decided to settle in Paris, which was at the time the most exciting hub for modernism, he could have apprenticed himself to any of the big names of Surrealism or Cubism but he chose Hecht instead.



Joseph Hecht, xxxxx

The two worked closely at Atelier 17. However, with the outbreak of the Second World War, Hayter left France for the United States. Hecht, who as a Jew, was in danger instead moved to Haut-Savoy near the Swiss-Italian border during the war. He worked as an agricultural labourer.

After the end of the war, the French authorities thought he had perished in the Holocaust and gave him a grand memorial exhibition, but he reappeared a few months later.

Hecht helped to re-establish the Atelier 17 giving his own press to start it off with. He also raised funds, mostly from other artists and critics to keep it going. However, Hecht was in poor health himself and not working.

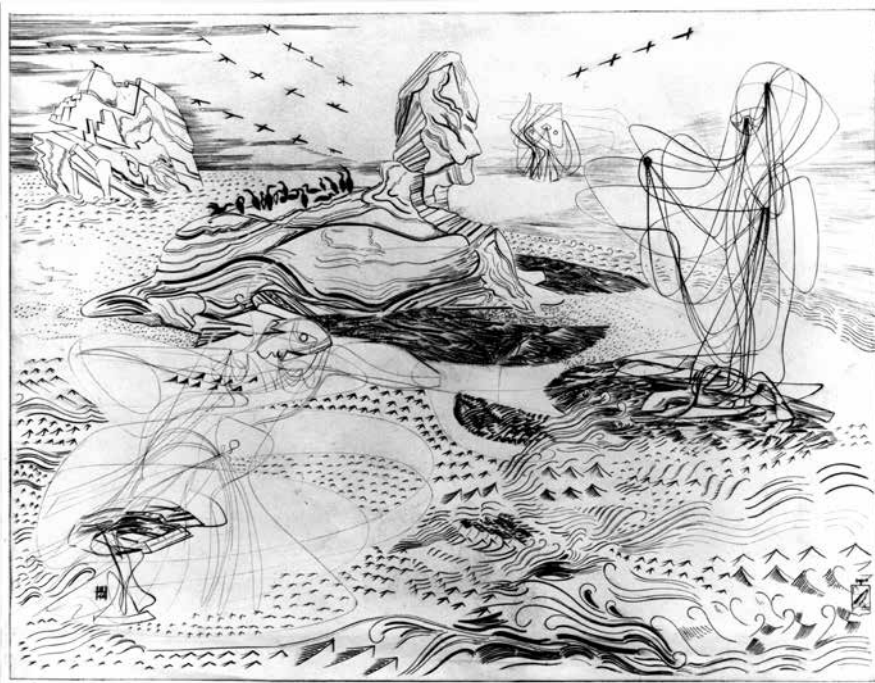
At one point when Hayter went off to the Planâge (the metal market) and returned with a huge copper plate, on which he started to engrave, tempting Hecht to follow suite in his own style. This remarkable act of friendship and support resulted in a historic large engraving entitled *La Noyée* which was bought by many museums. Hecht died of a heart attack in 1951 and received a number of posthumous honours and exhibitions, among others at the Bezalel Museum in Israel. Unfortunately I never met Hecht



Jósef Hecht, Pont de
Flanders, engraving,
1934



Jósef Hecht, Rue de
Mouffetard, engraving,
1934



as he had died before I had arrived in Paris. However, I had the good fortune to be able to purchase his Paris suite which consisted of 10 superb engravings in a traditional canvas portfolio all signed and numbered by him. For good measure, he had put his home address on the back of each print, so that people could get in touch for further purchases.

Jósef Hecht, William Hayter, *La noyée*, engraving, w1946

Ethos and Organization of the Atelier 17

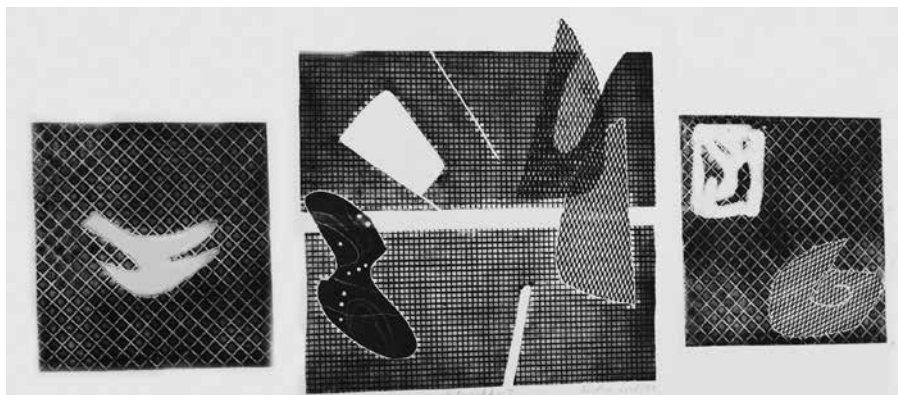
When a student started work, he or she had to undertake a first experimental plate. This was quite small and could be either zinc or preferably copper. Large sheets of unpolished copper could be bought up relatively cheaply on the Planâge, the big metal market, but before it could be used, it had to be cut up with a guillotine and hand-polished.

Bill encouraged you to start by drawing or engraving a line, made in an 'automatic' fashion, that is to say that it was like a sub-conscious scribble and did not attempt to depict any realistic detail. You then followed this by adding several layers of soft ground etching, when various materials were pressed into the soft wax of the plate with the help of the etching press and its felt blankets. The main areas could then be picked out and covered with varnish and the rest of the plate could be deep etched.

At this point, it seemed that people had landed themselves in a hell of a mess, with a meaningless technical display, but this was the stage, when the real creative work started. Students were encouraged to drastically scrape down and polish up areas or aquatint and deep bite others, thereby organizing the space and discovering the content in their own work. This introduction seemed so inclusive and effective, that I have used it throughout my teaching career. After this experiment, students should have had the necessary technical knowledge to start on larger plates with their own design.

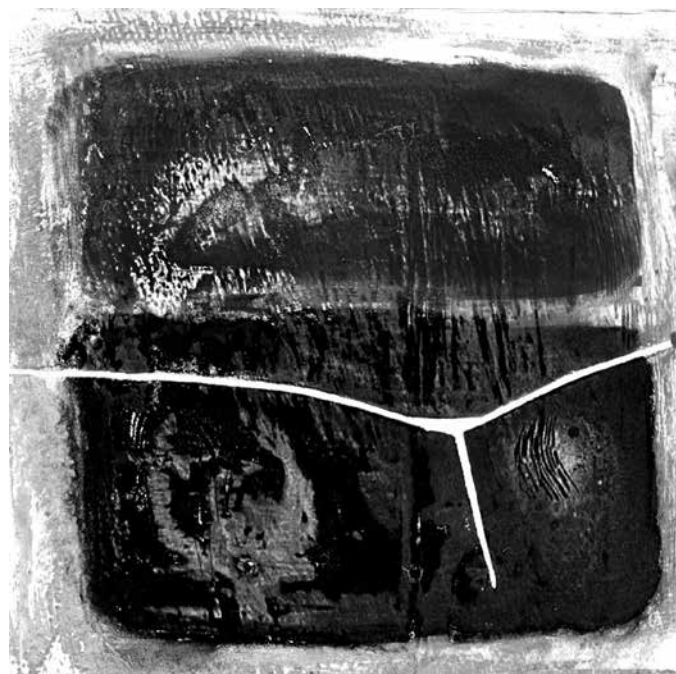
I however, had a very special problem. I was taught to work by teachers who followed the social realist canon, against which I had rebelled, but did not have the means to escape. My generation missed out completely on the discoveries of the entire period

Agathe Sorel
Petrushka, Pressed
aluminium collage,
1961





**Agathe Sorel, *Fumée*,
line engraving, 1961**



**Agathe Sorel, *Troubled square*, engraving,
1963**



Agathe Sorel, *Après la Moisson*, etching 1959

of modern art from Impressionism onwards, as it was declared degenerate by the Nazis, and decadent by the Communists. This made it difficult to see examples of any of this work while I was in Hungary. I could not, of course, find out all about this period by myself. Bill helped me a great deal and I started to go to museums and art galleries to fill in the gaps of my knowledge, but I was not yet entirely comfortable with contemporary art.

Whilst working with Hayter, I began to use exaggeration, simplification and selection or superimposition of frames of reference to express ideas and to invoke past experience. Having rejected photographic reality or social realism in which we were instructed in Hungary, this was for me a leap into the dark. I made a number of prints at that time in Paris that were groundbreaking. Amongst them was *Saule Pleureur* or *Fumée* 1959. For this, I ploughed up the copperplates with a burin creating a negative sculpture, which was against all the rules at the time.

In *Vue sur la Montagne*, also made in 1959 in Paris, I managed to create a sculptural effect by scraping into the soft zinc plate and hammering into it which created a surface which took colour applied by a roller in an organic way. Here I used both intaglio and surface colours and brute force.

Salvador Dalí

I managed to rent a very civilized apartment opposite Hayter's studio in an elegant period house where there were only four apartments. On the ground floor lived a professional engraver, who in spite of his great disability, a crippling deformity of his arm and hand, managed to attract many leading artists with his skills. He could interpret their drawings or sketches in a most elegant way and line engraving was his specialty.

I often saw a great limousine with darkened windows pulling up before our gate and Salvador Dalí came out, while his chauffeur remained in the car trying to ward off the police. It was rather surprising that Dalí chose to hire the services of a professional engraver, when he himself was an extremely good technician, his skills having been honed and perfected since early childhood.

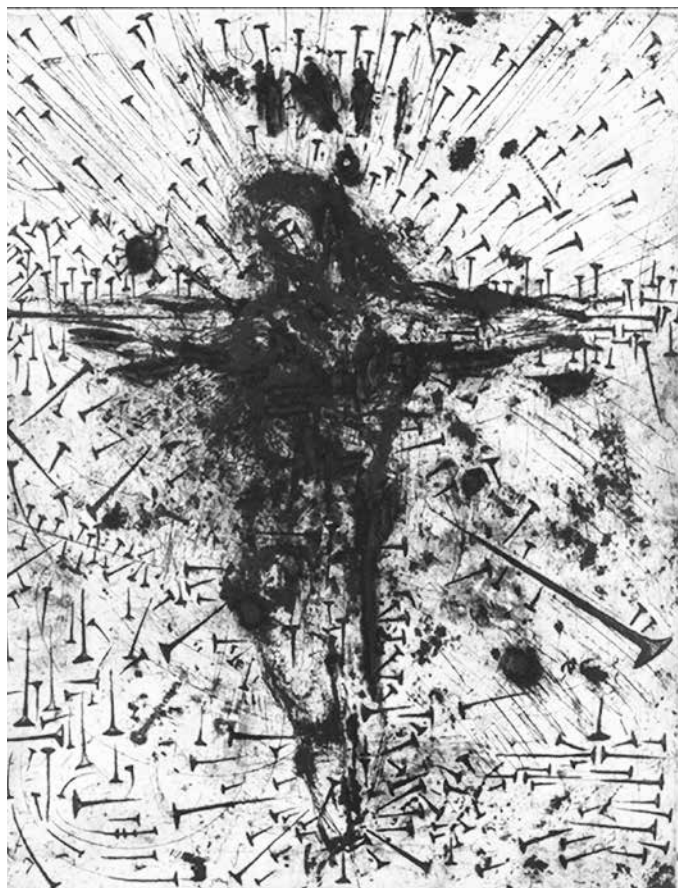
In any case he ordered two life size portraits of La Fontaine to be engraved in the classical style after his sketches and when they were finished he came along with some equipment in a large bag. A great deal of rather alarming noise disturbed the street and it turned out that Dalí shot into one of the copper plates with a rifle and let loose an electric drill on the other one. These produced a magnificent rich tone when the plates were inked up for printing alongside the rather sober engravings.

Dalí was often depicted as a thoughtless prankster, chasing after money all the time, but equally he is recognized as one of the most important Surrealist masters.

Salvador Dalí at work



Salvador Dalí,
*Frontispie for Les
 Métamorphoses
 Érotiques*,
 drypoint with electric
 drill and nails pressed
 into the plate, 1969



I managed to buy one of these portraits of La Fontaine from the engraver and later on in the 1990s bought a most unusual book by Dalí, *Les Métamorphoses Érotiques* compiled in 1969 in commemoration of the Great Exhibition of 1851 and reproducing the original woodcuts of the exhibition catalogue in an intriguingly kinetic way. On the top page was an image from the Great Exhibition and below, Dalí created an image with the same contours but with very different content. Some of the images which Dalí transformed are shockingly erotic even considering it was published in the 1960s.

In the foreword Dalí emphasizes the difference between eroticism and pornography. His view is that eroticism is healthy, poetic and associated with love, in contrast to pornography which he despised.



Left: Salvador Dalí, *La Fontaine* Drypoint with electric drill making random marks, 1974

Right: Salvador Dalí, *Frontispiece for Les Métamorphoses Érotiques*, 1969

The book itself was published as a commercial edition in 1969 but a more exclusive edition of 150 was later printed by Atelier Rigal in Paris.
youtu.be/OkGfWZfRzWM Educational video on Dali You Tube

Jozsef Csáky

Whilst in Paris, I met a number of other renowned artists. My uncle Oscar had given me an introduction to the well-known Hungarian sculptor Jozsef Csáky. He was one of the first artists to interpret the ideas of Cubist painters like Picasso and Braque in sculpture. Despite coming from a poor family, he spent a great deal of time in the museums and galleries of Budapest. He attended the Academy of Applied Arts for a year and a half, but was highly critical of the teaching there. In 1908, attracted by stories of the great artists who worked there, he decided to move to Paris, and with just 40 francs in his pocket, he walked all the way there, a journey which took

Joseph Csáky
photographed by André
Kertész





Jozsef Csáky,
tyographic poster

him several weeks. There he kept himself by doing odd jobs, like carving tombstones or lettering or working as an artist's model. He did not even speak French at this stage, but he was soon accepted and helped by other artists and a Hungarian dealer and managed to get a studio in the same building as the other upcoming artists of the time, La Ruche designed by Gustav Eiffel.

He exhibited with the Cubists from 1911 onwards, his work selling well. During World War I, he joined the French Army as a volunteer and during World War II, he was involved in the French Resistance. We met him several times in between 1968-1969 in his fabulous studio in Montmartre.

Our photographer friend André Kertész made some memorable portraits of him.

By the time of our visits Csáky was an old man, whose work fell out of fashion because he returned to a kind of figuration based on Cézanne and Brancusi. The marble carvings rose from his studio floor like stalactites, like a luminous organic formation. He seemed to have had all kinds of difficulties with his health and also financial problems, but his daughter was there to help.

Apart from public commissions, his work can now be found in museums all over Europe and in the USA. It is high time his contribution to modern sculpture is re-evaluated.



Jozsef Csáky, *Femme à la cruche*, plaster, 1912

Victor Vasarely

To my great surprise, after being contacted by Uncle Oscar, I was sent a personal Invitation to the private view of my fellow Hungarian Victor Vasarely's exhibition at the Galerie Denise Renée in 1959. Vasarely introduced me to everyone as an up-and-coming young artist.

I remember having a long conversation with Françoise Gilot, at the gallery, one of the few women, who left Picasso voluntarily and with some dignity, who was writing a critical biography and analysis of the great master at the time¹⁶.

Vasarely was born in 1906 in Transylvania but later moved to Budapest. His father insisted that he should study medicine but he soon realized that his real interest was in the arts and joined Sandor

Portrait of Victor
Vasarely, 1960





**Fondation Vasarely
Aix-en-Provence an
impressive building
later abandoned
and the material
transferred to Hungary**

Bortnyik's¹⁷ private art school called the Mühely (the workshop) which was organised along Bauhaus principles. As they did not have the resources of the Bauhaus in Germany, they concentrated on applied graphic art, and typography. However, they taught these subjects to such a high level that work from this period is still admired and collected by museums all over the world.

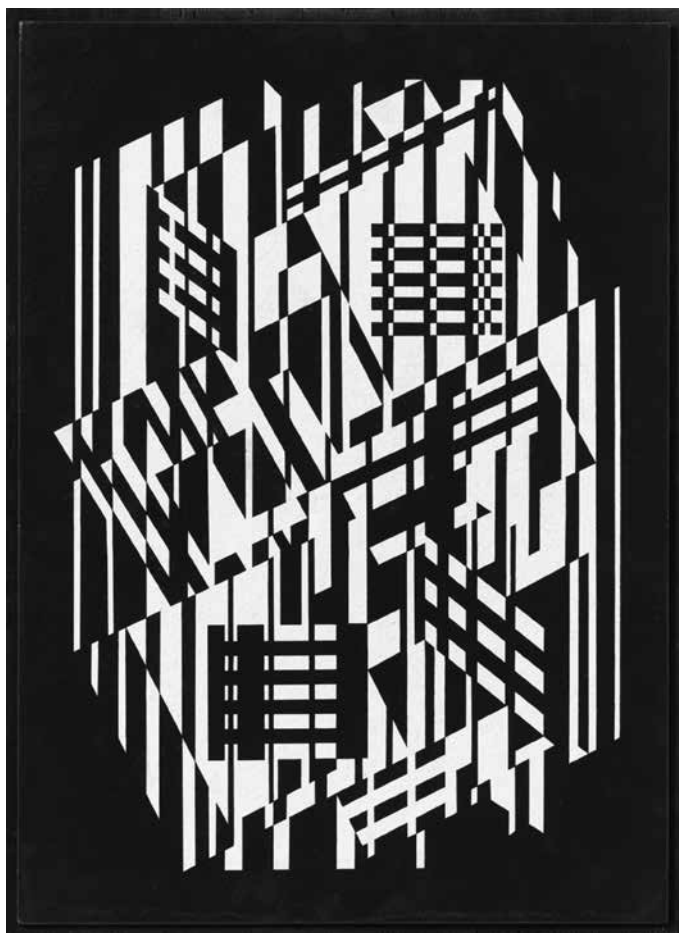
Sandor Bortnyik was the director of the Academy of Fine Arts when I was a student there and Robert Berény, his fellow pupil, was head of department. Neither dared to show us students the significant and ground-breaking work of their past.

Vasarely left Hungary to live in Paris in 1930 and started his own workshop on the outskirts of the city. He first experimented with organic forms and inserted photography into his images before experimenting with optical illusions between 1941 and 1951. This led to experiments in kinetic art between 1952 and 1955. In all of these areas he was way ahead of his time. His students and assistants assured an almost factory type production and he came up with the idea of serial art where he uncompromisingly questioned the uniqueness of a work of art. Nevertheless, his

¹⁶ Françoise Gilot published *Life with Picasso* in 1964

¹⁷ See Volume 1 for further details of this artist

Victor Vasarely, AFA
Negativ, Tempera on
panel, 1957



rather intriguing but decorative images sold like hotcakes. His attitude, of course, was totally contrary to the ideals of the Atelier 17, where everything was hand-made and instinctive, based on the subconscious. There, communication between artists was by word of mouth. I think both of these approaches are valid and I benefited from both, having made my own conclusions and observations to understand the visual world. His work was represented at the now defunct Vasarely Museum at Aix on Proviunce and more permanently at the Vasarely museum in Buda Hungary.

<https://youtu.be/PNfEYgfibmY> Vasarely museum Budapest youtube

<https://youtu.be/jKqLeLXdj7w>

My relations

Ibi and Micu Salgo were my mainstay while I was working in Paris. Ibi was my grandfather Adolf's sister from Transylvania. Their daughter Jeanne, who was about the same age as I was, had just finished her medical training and was also a psychoanalyst. Both Ibi and Piri, Micu's sister, a brilliant pianist, escaped from Transylvania and Hungary before the persecution of Jews in that part of the world reached disastrous proportions and before the borders were completely sealed off. The family had managed to get to Israel and then moved to Paris post-war through arduous and frustrating adventures.

Jeanne met a Moroccan Arab music student at her aunt's piano lessons and a most improbable romance followed between a working class Muslim boy and a Jewish girl.

I was with Jeanne in a taxi, when she finally made the decision to marry him, despite being fully aware of the difficulties that might lie ahead.

The French government was extremely generous in those days towards talented and accomplished post graduate students. Jeanne's husband Mohamed Aboudrar was granted various opportunities and teaching jobs. They had two children, both wonderfully intelligent and successful. Their son Bruno Nassim Aboudrar is now professor of aesthetics at the Sorbonne as well as a successful author and essayist. He wrote a novel based on the story of his family. (*Ici Bas Gallimard*)

However, the marriage, did not last and Jeanne and Mohamed were divorced, possibly as a result of his alcoholism, though Jeanne still bears his name; He was never able to reach his full potential and returned to Morocco a disappointed man. He died of cancer of the larynx.



André Kertész, my Paris relatives Ibi and Micu Salgo, who were good friends. This was made in the postcard format between 1928/32

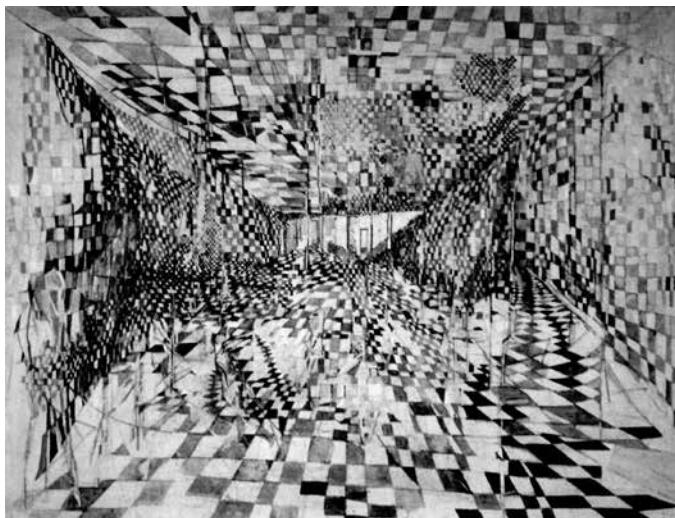
**Árpád Szenes (1897-1985)
and Maria Helena Viera da Silva (1908-1992)**

I had many connections to this famous artistic couple; first, there was of course the Hungarian connection through uncle Oszkar, who worked in Paris before the war. When I went to Paris, he suggested I contact them. Then there was a connection through Bill Hayter and Julian Trevelyan as they both worked with Szenes and Viera da Silva at various stages of their career.

Árpád was born in Hungary in 1897 to wealthy Jewish parents and, after a brief period of study and some success in exhibiting his work in Budapest, travelled in Europe and chose to study at the Académie de la Grande Chaumière in Paris. This is where he met

Maria Helena Viera da
Silva and Árpád Szenes
in their studio





Maria Helena Viera da Silva, from *Enigma*, 1947

his future wife Maria Helena Viera da Silva, who came from Lisbon. It was an exciting period to be in Paris, with Surrealism, Abstract Expressionism and many other art forms brought together into an artistic melting pot. This couple was way ahead of the game forming unique styles of expression. Árpád's work was abstract, quiet and contemplative, while Viera experimented with spatial ambiguities and colour. She became a worldwide success, every dealer's dream of a dependable and distinctive product. Árpád's work was appreciated more by the cognoscenti of the museum world, while Viera achieved popular and wide spread recognition. She won major prizes, including the Grand Prix National des Arts, the first woman thus honoured and she was named a Chevalier de la Légion d'Honneur.

<https://youtu.be/n3gp4Pd1IAE> You TubeVideo

One of his last projects involved the illustration of poems by Lorand Gaspar, the Hungarian-born French poet, whose work was the inspiration for my livre d'artiste *Catalana Blanca*.

I met them during my time in Paris when they invited me to their home but have to admit that at that point, still used to the world of social realism, I did not really appreciate their art and only visited them the once. Since then, I have had the opportunity to revisit my opinion, visiting major exhibitions of their work and meeting them again briefly.

In 1994, the couple established their own foundation and

museum in a former silk factory in Lisbon, where much of their work can be seen. I would like to visit, time and health permitting, to reevaluate their contribution, which has become more important through the passage of time.

Maria Helena Viera da Silva youtube https://youtu.be/n7UO_lpoQY4

Spreading my Wings

We were soon asked to exhibit any finished work, mostly at the yearly events of the Salon des Indépendants or the Salon de Mai where our work was shown alongside some very famous artists and also at the various biennials throughout the world. This was a tremendously exciting opportunity, through which I and my fellow-students made friends with other artists and art organizations in many other countries.

This was particularly the case for the USA where Hayter had recent ties and contacts. This is how I came across the Philadelphia Print Club and its director Bertha von Moschizker, who became a lifelong friend.

When we fled to England I had started an extensive correspondence with my mentor from Budapest Margit Graber, which continued throughout my stay in Paris I recently found about 13 detailed letters and a watercolour from her in a mysterious hidden drawer. How people understood the art of letter writing in those days! Her affection and attention surpassed even a mother's

Margit Graber, part of one of many letters to me written from her own window with a note on the verso. The blurred writing was caused by the use of cheap sugar paper. There were no shops to sell letter paper or envelopes in Hungary at that time



and her advice was always wise and useful. I would like to quote one of these letters here to give an idea of the important advice she shared with me about the life of an artist.

My dear Agi,

It is my fault for not replying sooner, but I miss your letters. It is not easy to answer your questions. We agree that you have to learn or study more. If you go into battle, you had better have the full armoury and you shouldn't be satisfied with the usual academic mores.

Cézanne shows the way forward. It seems most modern French artists from Matisse to the Cubists start from his ideas. Nevertheless, there are many problems waiting to be resolved.

Chardin and Corot are not so interesting today, because there is nothing more boring than yesterday's fashions.

When I still travelled abroad I could always identify Hungarian painting, they were somewhat decorative and could not compete with the French in wit and stylishness. I would advise you not even to try. We must not try to hide our laborious honesty even if what we do is not the height of fashion abroad.

I am not a believer in naturalistic painting, but the main source and inspiration of our art should still be reality to which we must hang on, even if the results are as far from reality as Picasso's clowns.

You have an innate intelligence; you can weigh things up and use your willpower. You should use puritanical endeavour in search for essence; things which are simple and true will always be effective.

It is a great gift that you have three undisturbed years at your disposal to work. Even if more difficult years wait ahead, don't go for quick success. You might achieve this with ease as you are smart, pretty and clever, but wait until others fight for success, this is not for you.

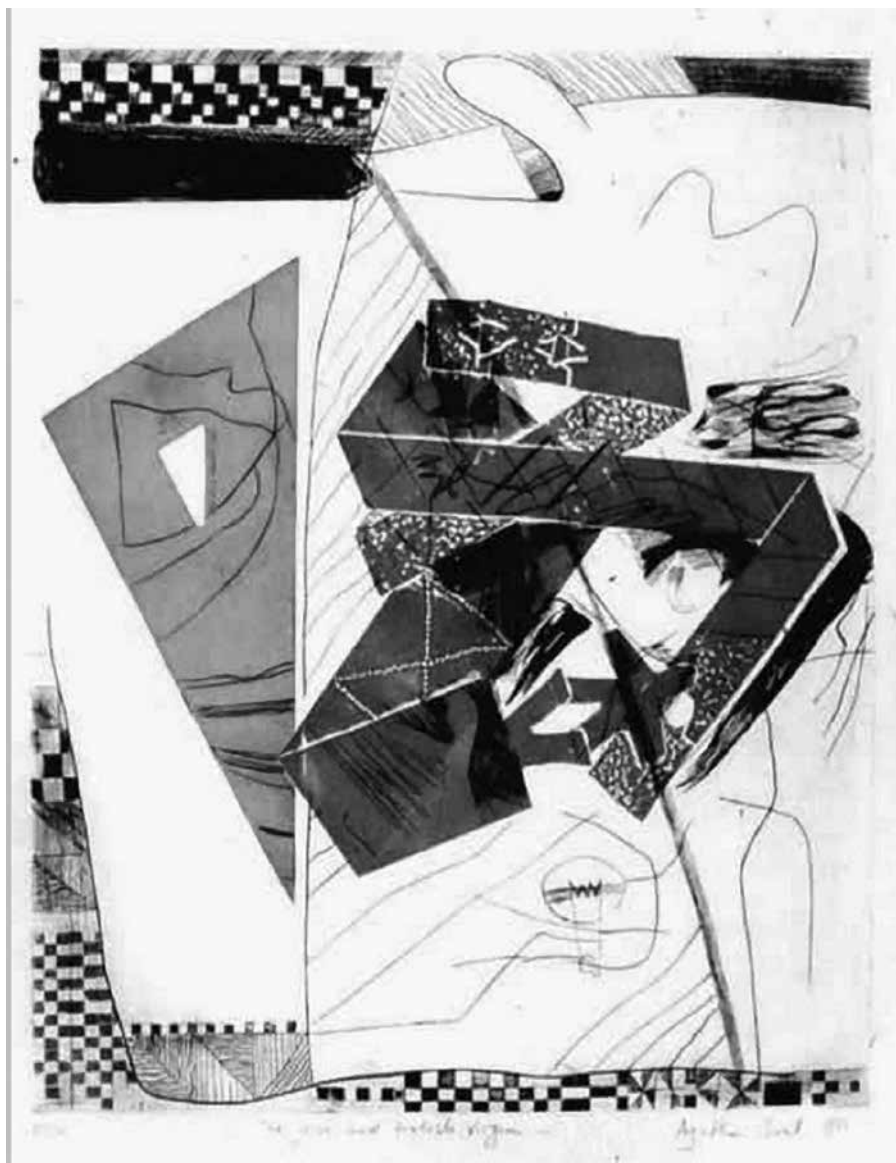
You can't complain that I don't write often, but as you see I do my best. It is a pity that now that you have grown up and your eyes are opening up I cannot see your work regularly and we cannot chat about art which interests us both. I feel I could help you more nowadays than when you were younger.

At home, the exhibition scene has changed. They arranged and are showing the funeral of socialist realism under the title of "Revolutionary Art" You can imagine the effect!

I worked a lot last summer and have decided to exhibit the results, but I don't know where as yet and it is not urgent. I live more and more quietly and prefer to be alone. I teach in an independent school and we have 110 students. I can see that beside the Academies there is a need for these schools, but talent there is as rare as white ravens.

My dear Agi, write to me soon and send me examples or photos of your work. Happy Christmas and good progress.

Love Aunt Medi



Agathe Sorel, *The Wise and Foolish Virgins*,
xxxxx, 1965

I often wondered why her letters were so blurred almost as if they were left out in the rain. But then it clicked; they were rather inexpertly steamed open by censors. I worried that her contact with someone in the west would have put her in danger.

I must have sent her photos of my work; she found my development with Hayter at the Atelier 17 in Paris rather surprising and it absolutely thrilled her. She was trying to explain the mind set and exploration in contemporary art to my father, who was more traditional in his thinking and thought the work of Chagall, Dalí or Max Ernst indicated a certain abnormality of the mind.

He was, of course, thrilled with my success and the opportunities which opened up for me in taking part so young in international exhibitions and the famous Salons which exhibited work from upcoming as well as established artists. Out of these the Salon des Indépendants, the Salon des Réalités Nouvelles and the Salon de Mai stand out and I found a contemporary article singling out and describing my work out of all the hundreds of exhibitors. The International Biennial exhibitions also presented an excellent platform and sales opportunities.

In spite of all this totally unexpected early success, I resented that every time I showed my work, people immediately commented that I was from the Hayter School and followed his style.

This changed when I started my own workshop back in London in 1960 and was able to experiment with different methods and materials.

My print *The Wise and Foolish Virgin*, 1966 (part of a triptych) included not only line engraving and aquatint, but an engraved acrylic set square, a small photogravure plate and a 3D hammered sculpture made of a thin bronze plate, flattened down to be printable. This was however not an abstract work, but was based on my own personal life story. Here instead of single plate printing, I used a constructivist approach towards assembling a found set square and the folded bronze low relief piece which I printed on top of the photographic and the linear base plate.

There are two unmistakable female characters occupying this complex sculptural space. It was exhibited in the first International Print Biennale in Bradford in 1969. Hayter was invited to be on the jury and came to the private view. I was literally shaking in my boots when I met him, as I had abandoned the Atelier 17 style to branch out on my own. He congratulated me for my research and achievement, and this was entirely characteristic of the generosity of spirit of this great artist.

We continued to see each other intermittently and I followed up by visiting his friends and museum contacts in the USA.



Margit Graber, my
mentor from Budapest